versa). Both the KGB and the GRU did have direct secure communications with their headquarters, but according to the KGB's Aleksandr Feklisov, Dobrynin expected to sign off on the most significant reports.[19]

The mechanics of formal communications in 1962 imposed constraints and created obstacles for decision-makers. This encouraged use of clandestine backchannels, which both leaders often preferred, and which, as previously noted, had been used to good effect in helping resolve the stand-off at Checkpoint Charlie in October 1961. Khrushchev also used ad hoc meetings with visiting Americans to send signals to Washington. For example, on 24 October a US businessman, William Knox, was suddenly summoned for a three-hour meeting at the Kremlin, at which Khrushchev admitted there were missiles (and nuclear warheads) in Cuba (when this was being denied in public), but in an attempt to reassure Kennedy, made clear the missiles were solely in Soviet hands and would never be fired first.[20]

Khrushchev's most important public messages were broadcast on Radio Moscow. While this saved time, it also created its own problems. When the Soviet demand to include the Turkish Jupiters in the deal was broadcast on Saturday, 27 October, it posed a greater political challenge for Kennedy than a private communication would have done (see below). There were also practical problems. Khrushchev's son, Sergei, recounts the story of how, with the smell of burning in the air (to use his father's phrase), the message from Khrushchev to Kennedy on 28 October announcing the withdrawal of the missiles was rushed from the Presidium to Radio Moscow:

> The official car carrying the message gets lost in the countryside between Khrushchev's dacha and the city, then it gets held up in traffic. Once inside Moscow Radio the messenger Leonid Ilichev gets stuck in the ancient lift. As it's a Sunday, there's no lift repairer in the building. Ilichev tries to push the letter through a crack in the lift doors, but its wax seal prevents it getting through and it tears. Finally, the lift judders into life, completes its